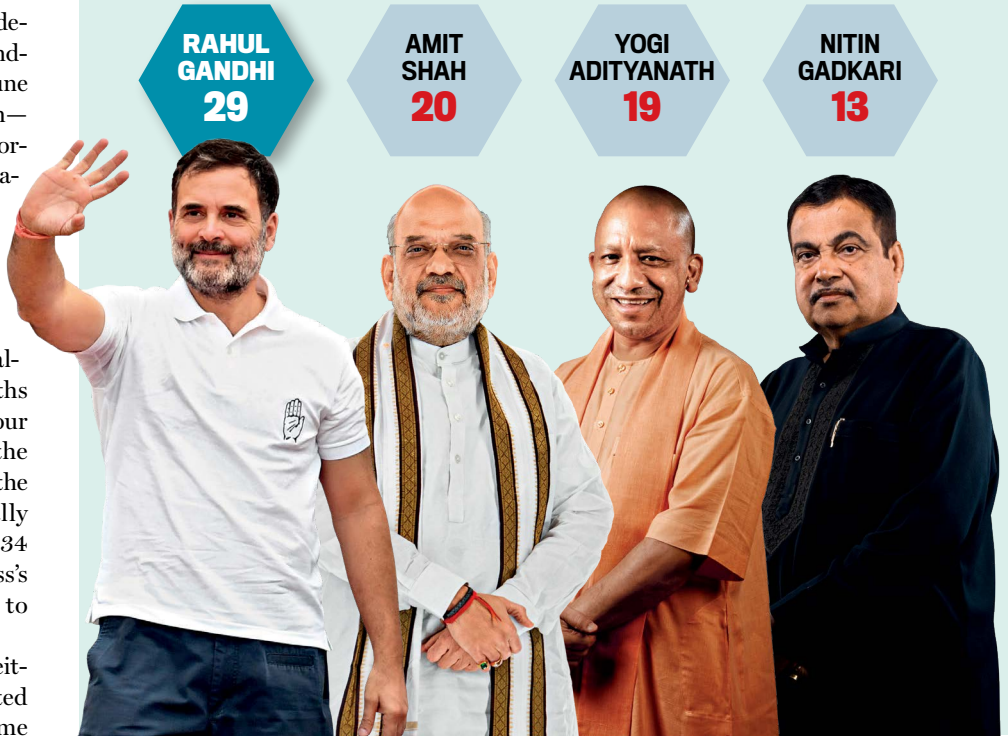
poll, the first after the May 2024 Lok Sabha election, holds significant pointers on how he should go about his third term, what he should prioritise and how to avoid the mistakes some of his predecessors made. Perhaps the biggest finding of the MOTN survey is that the June 2024 results were not an aberration—they neither give the BJP a full majority nor enough seats to the Indian National Developmental and Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) to unseat Modi and the BJP. Conducted between July 15 and August 10 this year, the poll shows that if a general election were held now, the results would be almost identical to those of two months ago. The BJP would get 244 seats, four more than the actual results and the NDA tally would go up to 299 from the current 293. The INDIA bloc's tally drops marginally, to 232 from the 234 it has actually won, but the Congress's individual tally moves up from 99 to 106 seats.

The August 2024 MOTN thus reiterates that the Indian electorate voted for continuity of the Modi-led regime but with several riders and caveats. Over a third of those surveyed said they believe that the Lok Sabha results were for continuity of his rule. But many also wanted a balance, with 12.5 per cent of the respondents saying the vote was for a strong Opposition. Asked how they rated the performance of Narendra Modi as prime minister, a high 58.6 per cent rated it as outstanding and good, a drop of just two percentage points from the MOTN exercise in February 2024. However, this rating was nowhere near the stratospheric 71 per cent Modi notched up in the August 2019 MOTN survey, soon after he won a second term as PM, and a rise of 17 percentage points from the poll six months earlier. Another discernible trend in the current MOTN is that the percentage of those who considered Modi's performance outstanding has fallen from 41.8 per cent to 34.3 per cent, a drop of 7.5 percentage points, while those rating it as good has gone up from 18.7 per cent to 24.3 per cent. Together, they show his sheen fading, while he continues to be seen as the tallest leader, with no clear alternative.

Q. Regardless of party affiliation, who is best suited to become prime minister after Modi?



All figures in % and rounded off; rest, others & don't know/ can't say (DK/ CS)

While Rahul Gandhi has emerged as the prime challenger to Modi, the PM still has a massive 27 percentage point lead over the Congress leader

The MOTN, though, does indicate a challenger on the horizon as Rahul Gandhi emerges from the shadows of his past failures. Asked who is best suited to be the next prime minister, Modi still has a 49.1 per cent rating, five percentage points less than in the previous MOTN. But Rahul's standing has jumped from 13.8 to 22.4 per cent in the same period, a leap of 8.6 percentage points. The gap between Modi and Rahul, though, is still a cavernous 26.7 percentage points, making it clear that the Congress scion poses no immediate threat to Modi's dominance in the political arena. Rahul does poll much higher than other BJP leaders such as Amit Shah, Yogi Adityanath and Nitin Gadkari when respondents were asked who is best suited to be prime minister after